

POLICYREADY • GEORGIA

How to Open a **Group Home Business** in Georgia

Host homes & community residential alternatives under the NOW & COMP waivers

Step by Step

*From “where do I start?” to your first payment —
whether you start with a host home, or your own provider agency.*

A complete, plain-language guide for real people — not lawyers or consultants.
Figures current for 2026 • Verify all details with the State of Georgia.

Read this first

This is a plain-language roadmap built from Georgia's actual rules, agencies, and waiver manuals. It is not legal, tax, or billing advice, and the details change — rates, codes, and regulations update quarterly. Before you act, confirm the current specifics with DBHDD, the Georgia Collaborative ASO, Healthcare Facility Regulation, your local fire authority, an attorney, an accountant, and an insurance broker. Every rule, code, and citation here is real and pulled from the state's own sources — but always check the current version before you rely on it.

What this guide covers

- Part 0 — The big picture: the NOW & COMP waivers, host homes vs. group homes, and the two ways in.
- Part 1 — Path A: a host home / life-sharing site under a CRA provider agency (the small, fast start).
- Part 2 — Path B: becoming your own CRA provider agency (run group homes, employ staff).
- Part 3 — Who you need on your team.
- Part 4 — The home: what your house needs (the CLA license, the 7-bed sprinkler rule, fire safety).
- Part 5 — Getting your first person placed.
- Part 6 — How you get paid: the CRA per-diem, tiers, and your first payment.
- Part 7 — What it costs and how long it takes.
- Part 8 — When they say “check locally”: who to call and exactly what to ask (Atlanta & Augusta worked out).

PART 0

The Big Picture

Opening a group home in Georgia is not like opening a normal small business, and the reason people get lost is that the information lives in a dozen different places. Here it is in one place.

Host home vs. group home — what you're actually opening

In Georgia, residential support for adults with developmental disabilities is a waiver service called Community Residential Alternative (CRA). It comes in two sizes. A host home (also called life-sharing) is a private home where the owner or lessee provides CRA services to one or two adults with developmental disabilities who aren't related to them by blood or marriage — the small, host-home-style option. A group home serves three or four residents in a licensed home. Both are CRA; the difference is size, licensing, and staffing.

The players — learn these names, you'll deal with all of them

- DBHDD — the Department of Behavioral Health and Developmental Disabilities. It runs the waivers day-to-day, enrolls providers, and sets the standards.
- DCH — the Department of Community Health, Georgia's Medicaid agency. It issues your Medicaid provider number and pays claims through GAMMIS.
- NOW & COMP — the two waivers: the New Options Waiver and the Comprehensive Supports Waiver Program. Residential (CRA) services are under COMP.
- Support Coordinator — the person who develops the Individual Service Plan (ISP) and coordinates services.
- Regional Field Office — one of six DBHDD offices; determines waiver eligibility and is your first local point of contact.
- Georgia Collaborative ASO — the administrative services organization that runs provider enrollment and provider relations.
- HFRD — Healthcare Facility Regulation (part of DCH); licenses group homes as Community Living Arrangements (CLAs).

The fork in the road — there are two ways in

This decides your scale and your paperwork.

- Path A — Become a host home / life-sharing site under an existing CRA provider agency. One or two adults live in your home; the agency supports you and handles the billing. Important: the Medicaid provider number belongs to the CRA agency, not to you — you subcontract with them. Fastest, simplest way in.
- Path B — Become your own CRA provider agency. You enroll with DBHDD and DCH, license your group homes, employ a Developmental Disabilities Professional (DDP) and staff, and can recruit your own host homes. Much bigger lift — but it's the real business.

PART 1 • PATH A

A Host Home / Life-Sharing Site

Start here. It's the fastest way in — and you can grow into your own agency later.

Step 1 — Make sure it fits your life

A host home means one or two adults with developmental disabilities live in your home and share your everyday life. They can't be related to you by blood or marriage, and you can't be an employee of the CRA agency you contract with. Everyone in the household is part of the screening — this is a family decision.

Step 2 — Choose a CRA provider agency

On this path you don't enroll with the state yourself — you partner with a DBHDD-approved CRA provider agency. They enroll your home (each host home requires its own site-specific enrollment), support and monitor you, and handle the billing. DBHDD keeps a list of approved NOW/COMP providers; interview more than one and ask how they support and pay host homes.

Step 3 — Pass background checks & training

You'll complete a criminal history background check and the training the agency and DBHDD require (including HCBS Settings Rule and health-and-safety topics) before the agency applies for your site-specific Medicaid provider number. The agency follows DBHDD policy 02-704 (enrolling, matching, and monitoring host homes).

Step 4 — Get your home ready

Your home has to pass the health-and-safety requirements for a host home site (see Part 4). A host home for one person is small and simple; if you'll serve two adults, additional requirements may apply — your agency will walk you through it.

Step 5 — Get matched

The agency, the person's Support Coordinator, and the Regional Field Office match you with someone whose needs and personality fit your home — the match is the heart of life-sharing. You'll sign an attestation and agreement with the agency.

Step 6 — Put your policies in writing

You'll keep clear documentation — medications, emergencies, incident reporting, and the rights of the person you support. PolicyReady's Georgia manuals are built for exactly this: ready to customize, just add your details.

Step 7 — Get supported, and get paid

The CRA agency bills Georgia Medicaid and pays you. Because the person lives in your home, your host-home payments may qualify for the IRS “difficulty-of-care” exclusion (potentially non-taxable) — confirm with a tax professional. That first payment is the moment it all clicks.

PART 2 • PATH B

Become Your Own CRA Provider Agency

More work, more money, more control. Here's the whole thing, in order.

Step 1 — Set up the business

- Form your entity (LLC or corporation) with the Georgia Secretary of State and get your EIN.
- Get a Type 2 (organizational) NPI (free) — you'll need it for Medicaid enrollment.
- Line up your Developmental Disabilities Professional (DDP) — a required role who must be primarily employed by your agency.

Step 2 — Attend the New Provider Enrollment Forum & submit your Letter of Intent

Enrollment runs through the Georgia Collaborative ASO. You register for and attend a New Provider Enrollment Forum, then submit an I/DD Agency Provider Letter of Intent (LOI) during an open enrollment period. Once the LOI is approved, you're invited to apply.

Step 3 — Submit your DBHDD provider application (and site visit)

Complete the DBHDD New Provider Application for the services and sites you'll offer. DBHDD may conduct a site visit, verifies you meet the criteria, and forwards a recommendation to DCH. This is guided by DBHDD policy 02-701.

Step 4 — License your group homes (CLA, through HFRD)

A group home serving two or more DBHDD-funded adults must be licensed as a Community Living Arrangement (CLA) by Healthcare Facility Regulation, under rule 290-9-37 (see Part 4). Secure the home, then apply through the HFRD portal — the license and your Medicaid site enrollment go together.

Step 5 — Complete Medicaid (DCH) enrollment

After DBHDD approves, you complete the online Department of Community Health (DCH) Medicaid application. Note: Medicaid provider numbers are service- and site-specific, so each CRA site is enrolled separately. If DCH denies, you must wait one year to reapply — so get it right the first time.

Step 6 — Insurance, policies & staffing, then serve

Carry the required insurance, put your policies and procedures in place (PolicyReady manuals), hire and train your staff, and complete New Provider Orientation. Then you can accept referrals, deliver CRA services, and bill (Parts 5 and 6).

PART 3

Who You Actually Need (Staffing)

Host home (Path A): you and your household are the support. The CRA agency provides the professional oversight, the DDP, and the billing, and helps arrange respite/relief. You don't build a staff.

CRA provider agency (Path B), plan for these roles — one person can wear several hats at the start:

- Agency director / administrator — runs the agency, owns compliance and the DBHDD/DCH enrollment.
- Developmental Disabilities Professional (DDP) — the required clinical/professional role; must be primarily employed by the agency with enough hours to meet participants' needs.
- Direct support professionals (DSPs) — the caregivers in your group homes; each background-checked and trained.
- Registered Nurse — for health oversight, medication, and nursing (RNs/LPNs need IDD Healthcare CEUs); often part-time or contracted at first.
- Billing / administrative support — handles GAMMIS billing, prior authorizations, and documentation.

PART 4

The Home: What Your House Actually Needs

The key distinction

A group home serving two or more DBHDD-funded adults must be licensed as a Community Living Arrangement (CLA) by Healthcare Facility Regulation. A host home serving one person is a private residence enrolled site-specifically under your CRA agency — lighter than a full CLA. Which you're opening changes what your house has to be.

“Do I need fire sprinklers?” — Georgia gives a clear answer

For a licensed CLA, the rule is refreshingly specific: a fire sprinkler system is required for a home with seven or more beds. A CRA group home (three or four residents) or a host home (one or two) is well under that, so a sprinkler system generally is not required. What you do need is a fire-safety inspection report from the appropriate fire authority (or State Fire Marshal), dated within 12 months, with no violations and showing the capacity load. Confirm anything unusual with your local fire authority.

THE CLA HOME CHECKLIST (RULE 290-9-37)

- A fire-safety inspection report (within 12 months, no violations, showing capacity load) — sprinklers only if 7+ beds.
- A floor sketch labeling rooms, doors, windows, and bed placement, with square footage.
- Approved water and sewage — a public water/sewer bill, or a County Environmentalist report for well/septic.
- Georgia Secretary of State registration for your entity, proof of ownership or lease, and background checks for owners (10%+ interest).
- HFRD inspects the home before licensure, then periodically and on any complaint — and you consent to unannounced visits.

Two more things people get wrong

- Zoning — a host home is defined as a private residence in a residential area, and small homes for people with disabilities are protected as residential use under the federal Fair Housing Act. Still, confirm your address and any local rules with your city or county.
- Room and board is separate from your pay. The CRA rate is for the service, not the resident's rent and food — residents pay their own room and board (usually from SSI). Keep the two separate.

PART 5

Getting Your First Person Placed

You can't get paid until someone is placed with you and services are authorized. Here's how that happens.

1. The person qualifies. They have an intellectual disability (originating before age 18) or a related developmental disability (before age 22), meet an ICF level of care, and are Medicaid-eligible. A DBHDD Regional Field Office determines waiver eligibility.
2. They have (or get) COMP funding. Residential CRA is a COMP service. Because waiver slots are limited, eligible people are placed on the I/DD Planning List and prioritized by unmet need.
3. The plan is built. Once funded, a Regional Planning List Administrator and Support Coordinator help the person and family choose providers and develop the Individual Service Plan (ISP).
4. The match and prior authorization. You (or your CRA agency) are matched to the person; the service and rate are prior-authorized in the Medicaid system before services start.
5. Move-in. The person moves in and, with services authorized, you're delivering a billable CRA service.

PART 6

How You Get Paid: The CRA Per-Diem & Your First Payment

How the rate works

Community Residential Alternative is paid as a per-diem (daily) rate — and Georgia sets different rate models for host home services and group home services. Within each, the rate is tiered by the resident's assessed needs, and for group homes it also reflects the home size (a three-person vs. a four-person residence). Higher acuity means a higher tier and a higher rate.

What drives your number

- Host home vs. group home: separate per-diem rate models — a host home (1–2 people) is priced differently from a group home (3–4).
- Tier (acuity): CRA rates step up by tier (roughly Tier 1 through Tier 4) based on the resident's assessed level of need.
- Home size: group home rates differ for a 3-person vs. a 4-person residence.
- Extra staffing: when a person needs hours beyond the rate-model assumptions, a separate Additional Residential Staffing service (basic or enhanced) can be authorized.
- Where to look: the exact procedure codes and current per-diem amounts are in the COMP fee schedule on GAMMIS (mmis.georgia.gov). Confirm the current figure before you budget.

How you bill — and one important rule

- Prior authorization first: every waiver service must be prior-authorized (PA) in the Medicaid system, and claims pay only according to the approved PA — confirm the PA is in place before you deliver services.
- Billed through GAMMIS: claims go to Georgia Medicaid via GAMMIS (a host home's claims are filed by the CRA agency).
- Room and board is separate — the CRA rate doesn't include it, and you never bill the person for a covered service.

Your first payment

6. Confirm the prior authorization matches the CRA service, tier, and site.
7. Deliver the service and keep your daily documentation.
8. Submit the claim through GAMMIS (the CRA agency does this for a host home).
9. Get paid — and remember claims pay per the approved PA, so keep authorizations current.

PART 7

What It Costs & How Long It Takes

Timeline

A host home (Path A) can move relatively quickly — screening, training, a home check, and site-specific enrollment through your CRA agency. Becoming your own CRA agency (Path B) is a months-long process: the enrollment forum and Letter of Intent (during an open enrollment window), the DBHDD application and any site visit, the CLA licensing of each group home, and DCH Medicaid enrollment. Because a DCH denial carries a one-year wait, plan carefully. Confirm current timelines with DBHDD and the Georgia Collaborative ASO.

Startup line items

Host home costs are modest — mainly your time, background checks, training, and getting your home ready. A CRA agency adds business formation, insurance, the DDP and staff payroll, the CLA license and fire/physical-plant requirements for each home, and your policies and procedures. Confirm current fees with HFRD and DCH.

PART 8

When They Say “check Locally”: Who to Call & What to Ask

In Georgia, your Regional Field Office and the Georgia Collaborative ASO are the center of gravity, with HFRD and your local fire authority close behind. Here's who to call and exactly what to ask.

The statewide offices (same for everyone)

For...	Contact
Becoming a provider (enrollment)	Georgia Collaborative ASO — georgiacollaborative.com (New Provider Enrollment Forum & LOI)
Waiver eligibility & local services	Your DBHDD Regional Field Office (dbhdd.georgia.gov/regional-field-offices)
Licensing a group home (CLA)	Healthcare Facility Regulation (HFRD) — 404-657-4076 • portal: gahles.dch.georgia.gov
Billing, fee schedule & prior auth	Georgia Medicaid via GAMMIS — mmis.georgia.gov
Crisis line (I/DD)	Georgia Crisis & Access Line (GCAL) — 800-715-4225

The local calls — and what to ask on each one

① YOUR DBHDD REGIONAL FIELD OFFICE / A CRA AGENCY — YOUR MOST IMPORTANT CALLS

- “I want to open a host home / a CRA group home in this area. What's the need, and can you point me to approved CRA agencies?”
- (To a CRA agency) “How do you enroll and support host homes, how do you match, and how and when do you pay?”

② HEALTHCARE FACILITY REGULATION (FOR A GROUP HOME) — THE CLA LICENSE

- “I want to license a Community Living Arrangement for [3 or 4] adults. How do I start, and what are the fire-safety and physical-plant requirements?”
- “Confirm the sprinkler rule for my bed count — my understanding is sprinklers are required only at 7 or more beds.”

③ LOCAL FIRE AUTHORITY — THE FIRE-SAFETY INSPECTION

- “I'm licensing a small residential home for [capacity] adults. What do you require for the fire-safety inspection, and how do I schedule it?”

Fully worked examples — Georgia's two biggest metros

Most people start in or near one of these two. Georgia is divided into six DBHDD regions — find yours with the regional field office locator.

ATLANTA (DBHDD REGION 3)

- Regional Field Office: DBHDD Region 3 — 100 Crescent Centre Parkway, Suite 900, Tucker, GA 30084; (770) 414-3052 (DD Regional Services Administrator: (770) 414-3046). Region 3 covers metro Atlanta.
- Enrollment: Georgia Collaborative ASO (georgiacollaborative.com) for the New Provider Forum and LOI.
- Licensing & fire: HFRD (404) 657-4076 for the CLA; the city (Atlanta) or county fire department for the fire-safety inspection.
- The local quirk here: metro Atlanta spans several counties — confirm which county your home is in for the fire inspection and any local zoning.

AUGUSTA (DBHDD REGION 2)

- Regional Field Office: DBHDD Region 2 (East Central Georgia, headquartered near Augusta) — find current contact via the DBHDD regional field office locator.
- Enrollment: same statewide Georgia Collaborative ASO process.
- Licensing & fire: HFRD (404) 657-4076 for the CLA; Augusta-Richmond County fire authority for the fire-safety inspection.
- The local quirk here: confirm whether your address is in the City of Augusta / Richmond County or a neighboring county — it changes your fire and zoning contacts.

How to find your own region & offices

10. Use the DBHDD regional field office locator (dbhdd.georgia.gov/regional-field-offices) — you're assigned by where you live.
11. Register for the Georgia Collaborative ASO New Provider Enrollment Forum to start the provider process.
12. For a group-home license, contact HFRD; for the fire inspection, call your city or county fire authority.

CORE RULES & REFERENCES

- COMP Waiver, Part III, Chapter 1700 — Community Residential Alternative (CRA) service requirements (on GAMMIS).
- DBHDD policy 02-701 (becoming a provider) and 02-704 (enrolling, matching, monitoring host homes/life-sharing).
- GA Rules & Regs 290-9-37 — Community Living Arrangements (CLA) licensing (HFRD).
- DBHDD Provider Manual for Community Developmental Disability Providers; COMP/NOW fee schedule on GAMMIS.

You can do this.

Opening a group home in Georgia is real work — the waiver system has a lot of moving parts — but it's a real, walkable path, and people across the state do it every day, giving someone a real home in the community.

You don't have to be a lawyer or hire a consultant. You need a safe home, a good heart, and a clear map — and now you have the map. Whether you start small with a host home or build your own agency, this guide takes you from your very first question all the way to your first payment.

Take it one step at a time, verify the current details with the State as you go, and lean on your Regional Field Office and the Georgia Collaborative ASO — that's what they're there for.

Prepared for PolicyReady.org. Grounded in Georgia DBHDD and DCH rules, the NOW and COMP waiver manuals, and the Georgia Rules & Regulations as of 2026. This guide is general information, not legal, tax, or billing advice. Requirements, rates, and codes change — always verify current details with the State of Georgia before you act.